

IN MEMORIUM The Museum of A. Ramachandran in Kollam realises a dream of the late artist (inset)



ART ▼

A HOME FOR HIS ART

A newly inaugurated museum celebrates the late artist A. Ramachandran's creative journey—from his Kerala roots to his vibrant explorations of form, myth and modernity

The Museum of A. Ramachandran in Kollam, inaugurated on October 5, realises a dream the artist, who passed away in 2024, cherished for decades—to create a home for his art in Kerala. "Although Ramachandran spent all his working life in Delhi, he remained a Malayali at heart," says R. Siva Kumar, the museum's curator. "His sensibilities were formed during his early days in Kerala [Attingal and Thiruvananthapuram], and they shone through his personality and his art."

Ramachandran's fascination with art began early: childhood scribbles on walls, oil portraits of ancestors, temple murals and reproductions of Bengal School paintings nurtured his curiosity. A visit to Sri Chithralayam in Thiruvananthapuram and, years later, the Maruki Gallery in Japan inspired his lifelong wish to build a museum of his own. That wish was realised posthumously through the efforts of his family, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby and the Kerala government. The museum now stands within the Sree Narayana Guru Cultural Complex, symbolising both artistic and cultural belonging.

"The museum allows viewers to experience the works chronologically while placing them in context through short wall texts, a studio recreation and digital presentations," explains Siva Kumar. "It lets viewers know the artist at many levels."

The collection traces Ramachandran's journey from the dark expressionism of the 1960s to the radiant, nature-based imagery of his later years. "While they are apparently contrary, there is an innate rebelliousness running through both periods," notes Siva Kumar. "In that sense, he was a critical

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